Event Technology Awards: AI Edition

➔ **Rosch, Piper, Ethan**

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🏆 **Most Innovative AI Application in Events**
Celebrating groundbreaking AI ideas or applications that push the industry forward and deliver clear, creative impact.

Questions / Answers

ENTRANT DETAILS

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COMPANY INFORMATION

Company / Organisation Name
Piper

Product Name (optional)
Piper Pitch

Company profile
Piper is a production finance platform for live events, built with generative AI as the native interface for how event companies manage money. Co-founded in October 2025 by Ethan Rosch and Taylor Pagitt, with 40 years between us producing events for Apple, Nike, Google, Facebook, Intel, and Mastercard. Piper was born from direct experience of managing high-stakes budgets with inadequate tools, and watching businesses fail because of it.

Built on Anthropic's Claude, a deliberate choice for its structured output reliability and responsible AI philosophy, with all prompts managed through Langfuse for version control and observability. Advised by Isaac Kargar, PhD (AI architecture) and Karl Johansson (CFO, financial modelling).

The platform is designed in three tiers: Piper Pitch (live, budgeting through AI), Piper Produce (in development, quote and invoice lifecycle tracking), and Piper Finance (in development, 13-week rolling cash-flow visibility across all projects). We serve production companies, agencies, and freelance producers managing budgets from £50k to £5M+, currently onboarding beta testers with design partner discussions underway.

YOUR PRODUCT

Questions / Answers

Description of your technology

Live events are made by people. The creative vision, the client relationships, the split-second decisions on a production floor. No technology replaces these. But the industry's challenge has never been too many people — it's too few people doing too much. Producers juggling 400 line items at midnight. Coordinators chasing quotes across twelve email threads. Finance teams catching a £40K overage on page seven of a PDF at 6pm on a Friday. That's the job for AI. Not the creative seat — the work that buries the people sitting in it.

Event companies, production agencies and experiential marketing teams manage millions in costs across concurrent projects, many using spreadsheets or generalist tools like Monday.com (https://Monday.com). Event tools aren't much better. ProCim feels designed for accountants. Scoro slows producers down. Showbiz Budgeting hasn't evolved in decades. The result: budgets are clunky, manual documents disconnected from the work they're tracking, and cash flow is managed by gut feel and guesswork.

Before Piper, this kind of solution didn't exist in events. Piper is an AI-native financial platform purpose-built for event production, co-founded by two producers who've lived the problem and built on Anthropic's Claude. The inspiration was personal: we were directly affected when a 35-person London event agency collapsed under cash-flow mismanagement, and Taylor, as a client, was sent a $10 million event budget by a 150-person agency that had pulled the wrong subtotals from its own spreadsheets. The industry needs more than better spreadsheets and nifty template offerings. It needs a financial backbone designed for how event businesses actually operate.

Event production isn't static or repeatable. Change is the only constant. Vendor quotes arrive at midnight. Budgets are living documents that shift with every client conversation. Piper is built for that reality.

Piper Pitch (live): Win the project.

Piper Pitch answers "how much is this going to cost?" Four AI capabilities transform how budgets are created and managed. Smart Start generates a budget scaffold from a natural language event description. Smart Add lets producers build line items through conversation or by uploading vendor quotes, and the AI extracts, structures, and maps items to the budget. AI Budget Review generates a full report in under 60 seconds. Ask Piper answers natural language questions about live budget data and models the financial impact of scope changes.

Piper Produce (in development): Run the project.

Quote and invoice tracking with payment and approval tracking against line-item codes through six lifecycle stages, from Forecast through to Paid. Discrepancies are flagged before they become problems.

Together, Piper Pitch and Piper Produce track every cost from first estimate to final payment, with AI at every stage. The innovation isn't a single AI feature. It's an AI-native platform for a vertical that has been invisible to technology builders.

A chaptered Version of the video: https://player.mediadelivery.net/play/633061/fa946229-ea4d-4251-ba45-26fcc63294a6 (https://player.mediadelivery.net/play/633061/fa946229-ea4d-4251-ba45-26fcc63294a6)

TECHNOLOGY DESCRIPTION

Questions / Answers

Explain how the AI works in your solution?

Four AI capabilities serve different stages of the production finance workflow, all built on Anthropic's Claude.

Smart Start generates a structured budget scaffold from a natural language event description or uploaded files from previous events, including Excel and PDFs, creating sections and subsections in seconds from a blank page.

Smart Add lets producers build budget items through natural language or document upload. The AI generates structured line items with rates, quantities, section placement, and confidence scores. Currency conversion is automatic. Producers iterate conversationally until the output is right.

AI Budget Review generates a categorised analytical report covering rate anomalies, duplicate charges, missing categories, and staffing gaps in under 60 seconds, constrained by strict JSON schema validation.

Ask Piper answers natural language questions about live budget data. "What happens if I add 100 guests?" generates cost projections, affected line items, and a draft client communication.

Every prompt encodes production knowledge from decades of combined experience. The AI knows a scenic quote without transport is incomplete, that freelancer rates vary by role, and that a vendor summary page doesn't always match the detail.

No output reaches the budget without the producer's explicit approval. The AI works; the producer decides.

What specific problem does this AI solve?

Production finance is the operational backbone of every event company, and it's running on tools that weren't built for the job.

Event production budgets are high-stakes, living documents. A typical production has 200-500 line items across 15-30 sections, with 20+ vendor quotes arriving in different formats. The current workflow: read each PDF line by line, manually transcribe into a spreadsheet or legacy platform, assign sections, calculate markup, check your work, hope you didn't miss anything. A single AV quote takes an hour. A budget review is skipped when deadlines get tight. Cash-flow visibility is non-existent until it's too late.

The tools that exist, ProCim, Scoro, Showbiz Budgeting, were built for static, repeatable businesses. Event production is neither. Every show is different, scope changes constantly, and the financial picture shifts with every client conversation. These tools don't bend.

Piper solves this by applying AI to production finance from the architecture up, not as an add-on to an existing platform, but as the core interface. Budgets are built through conversation, vendor quotes are processed in seconds, reviews are generated systematically, and financial questions are answered instantly. The entire workflow is reimagined for how event businesses actually operate.

Questions / Answers

What makes your approach different or innovative?
Three things make Piper's approach genuinely new.

First: we are building for a vertical no one has built for. AI has been applied to attendee engagement, event marketing, matchmaking, registration, and content generation. Production finance, the system that determines whether a show makes or loses money, has been largely ignored. We haven't seen another AI-native platform built specifically for this function. Existing tools digitise spreadsheets. Piper replaces the workflow entirely.

Second: built by the people who live the problem. Adjacent-industry founders who don't understand events "fall out quite quickly because they don't get any traction," as one industry leader put it. Taylor and I have managed budgets on Apple product launches, NYFW, and Cannes Lions. Every feature exists because it was needed on a real show. That domain knowledge is encoded into the AI, so the platform understands event-specific patterns generic tools miss.

Third: complete financial infrastructure, not a point solution. Piper isn't just AI-powered budgeting. It's a three-tier financial platform: Piper Pitch (create and manage budgets), Piper Produce (track every cost from forecast through payment), Piper Finance (13-week cash-flow visibility across all projects). No other platform we've found connects estimation to financial outcome with AI running through every layer.

VALIDATION

How did you test, validate, or quality-check the AI outputs to ensure they were accurate, safe, or reliable?
Innovation demands trust. If producers don't trust the AI's output, they won't use it, and a financial platform that isn't used is just a demo. We approached validation as a product decision, not a compliance exercise. The question wasn't "how do we prevent errors?" but "how do we build a system where the producer always has enough information to make a confident decision?"

Every AI output arrives with context for the producer's judgement. When Smart Add extracts a line item from a vendor quote, it includes a confidence score: high when the rate and section placement are unambiguous, lower when the AI is interpreting unfamiliar formatting or ambiguous terminology. The producer sees exactly what the AI is certain about and what it's guessing. Low-confidence items are visually flagged. High-confidence items still require explicit approval before they touch the budget.

The underlying architecture enforces this through strict output schemas. Smart Add can only return items with required fields: description, quantity, rate, unit type, section. AI Budget Review can only return findings with categories, severity levels, and specific line item references. If the AI produces anything that doesn't conform, the system surfaces an error rather than displaying partial or malformed results.

Prompts are versioned and managed through Langfuse, separate from application code. This means we iterate on AI quality at the speed of prompt engineering, deploying improvements in minutes rather than code release cycles. Smart Add has evolved through 8 major prompt versions, each tested against documents from real productions. When one version reduced accuracy on multi-page PDFs, we caught it through trace analysis within hours and rolled back without touching the codebase.

Isaac Kargar, PhD (Principal AI Scientist, published in IEEE) advises on model selection and validation architecture. Karl Johansson (CFO) ensures financial workflows hold up against real-world production finance requirements. The result: innovation in what the AI can do, discipline in how it's allowed to do it.

Questions / Answers

IMPACT

In one summary, explain the overall impact of your AI solution. Please cover four areas: innovation, execution, user or customer outcomes, and measurable results.

Innovation

The events industry generates billions annually. Every pound and dollar flows through production finance: budgets, quotes, invoices, cash flow, reconciliation. Until Piper, we hadn't seen an AI-native platform for any of it.

This isn't an incremental improvement to an existing tool. It's a new category.

The market gap is structural. AI has transformed how events handle attendee engagement, marketing, and logistics. But the financial operations behind every event, the systems that determine whether a show is profitable, have been invisible to technology builders. The tools that exist were designed for other industries. ProCim and Scoro come from project management and accounting backgrounds. Showbiz Budgeting hasn't meaningfully evolved in decades. None of them were built by people who've actually produced events, and none of them were built with AI as the core interface.

Piper doesn't add AI to an existing platform. It was architected from day one with AI as the primary interface, built on Anthropic's Claude, with domain-specific prompts encoding decades of combined production experience. The result is a platform where budgets are built through conversation rather than forms, vendor quotes are processed in seconds rather than hours, reviews are generated systematically regardless of deadline pressure, and financial questions are answered instantly from live data.

The vision extends beyond budgeting. What's live today is Piper Pitch: how much is this going to cost? But the platform is designed as three tiers. Piper Produce adds quote and invoice lifecycle tracking, matching incoming costs against budget line items through six stages from Forecast to Paid. Piper Finance adds a 13-week rolling cash-flow dashboard across all projects, the kind of visibility that might have prevented the agency collapse that inspired the platform.

On the roadmap: a company memory layer (Memo) that learns pricing patterns and vendor history, so when a producer asks "How much should I budget for florals in San Antonio?" the platform draws on every show the company has run. And a Chrome extension sidekick that processes incoming quotes from email before the producer even opens Piper.

The paradigm shift is real. Piper moves producers from doing the work to reviewing it. In production finance, that's happening for the first time.

Questions / Answers

Execution

We built Piper from October 2025. Five months from founding to production-ready platform with four integrated AI capabilities. That speed reflects a team that already knew exactly what to build.

Ethan Rosch (25 years producing live events, including NYFW site production, Es Devlin/Instagram at Cannes Lions, and countless corporate productions) and Taylor Pagitt (15 years as an executive producer and client for Apple, Nike, Google, Expedia Group, and Mastercard) didn't need a discovery phase or user research sprint. Every capability was designed from real production scenarios. Version comparison exists because we were asked, "what changed since Tuesday?" in a client meeting. AI Budget Review exists because no one catches duplicate charges under deadline pressure. Smart Add exists because transcribing vendor quotes is the most universally hated task in production.

We evaluated multiple foundation models before choosing Anthropic's Claude. For a platform where a single misextracted rate can cost a client thousands, we needed a model that excels at returning precisely structured data and a provider whose approach to AI safety mirrors our own principle: the AI should never make decisions on the producer's behalf.

AI behaviour lives in Langfuse, not in the application code. This separation lets us improve how the AI interprets a venue hire contract or a multi-currency equipment quote without shipping a new build. Smart Add's extraction prompt has gone through 8 iterations since launch, each refined against real documents that exposed edge cases the previous version handled poorly.

Isaac Kargar, PhD (Principal AI Scientist, 10+ years deep learning, published in IEEE) guides AI architecture. Karl Johansson (CFO) validates financial workflows against real-world production finance requirements. The combination of production experience, AI research, and financial discipline ensures the platform serves all three stakeholders: producers, finance teams, and clients.

Infrastructure is built for scale. Supabase (PostgreSQL) with row-level security scoping every query to the authenticated user's data. JWT authentication. No client-side secrets. Sentry for error monitoring. GitHub Actions CI/CD with migration testing. Claude Sonnet handles complex generation requiring deep context; Claude Haiku handles lighter tasks where speed matters most.

Every AI interaction is traced end-to-end through Langfuse. We measure against real vendor quotes, real budgets, and real production scenarios, not synthetic benchmarks.

Five months from founding to production-ready. Now onboarding beta testers and in design partner discussions.

Questions / Answers

Outcome

Piper is creating a new category in event technology: AI-native production finance.

Before Piper, production companies managed their most critical function, how money flows through the business, using tools not designed for the job. Budgets lived in spreadsheets with broken formulas and exposed markup columns. Vendor quotes were transcribed manually with errors compounding across documents. Cash flow was tracked on instinct. The disconnect between production teams and finance teams was structural.

With Piper, that changes. Producers describe what they need, review what the AI generates, and commit what's right. The quality of decisions improves because the AI surfaces findings a human reviewer would miss under deadline pressure. The speed of delivery improves because mechanical work is handled by the AI rather than the producer. Client-ready output is produced in one action rather than hours of manual cleanup.

The most significant outcome is the shift in how producers spend their time. Piper moves them from doing the work to reviewing it: less time on data processing, more on the creative and strategic decisions they got into the industry to make. The AI handles the mechanical labour. The producer exercises the expertise that only comes from years of experience on live events.

As Piper Produce comes online, the outcomes extend further. Quotes and invoices tracked with payment and approval tracking against budget line items through six stages from Forecast to Paid. Every cost matched before a bill is disputed.

Because a producer at 1am deserves a second pair of eyes that never gets tired.

Results

The workflow change is fundamental. Piper replaces manual, form-driven financial work with a generative interface where producers describe what they need and curate what the AI generates.

Budget reviews that were skipped under deadline pressure now happen every time. The AI generates a systematic analytical report regardless of how much time is left. On real budgets, it consistently surfaces findings experienced producers acknowledge they would have missed, including markups miscalculated relative to project standards, duplicate charges across sections, and staffing positions without day rates.

Financial questions that required spreadsheet modelling are answered conversationally in seconds. During a live meeting, the answer is available before the conversation moves on. Client delivery that required hours of manual sanitisation is reduced to a single action, with internal and client data separated at the platform level.

Version comparison is structural. When a client asks "what changed?" the answer is generated instantly rather than reconstructed from memory or email.

A long-time production manager's immediate reaction to Smart Start was: "The 'enter your event brief and Piper creates a budget' is such a fantastic feature. It's like the hero that seriously saves time. It's what grabbed my attention most."

These are results from a five-month-old platform in its first iteration, live, continuously improving through the Langfuse observability pipeline, and building toward the full three-tier financial infrastructure.

Questions / Answers

CASE STUDY

Describe how the AI was used in practice.
To demonstrate Piper's capabilities, we built a real budget during a live call with a producer who manages her own budgets in spreadsheets. The scenario: a private members' club residency during London Book Fair at Old Sessions House, with a daytime exhibition for 80 guests, an evening party for 100, two hosted dinners, and production, AV, print, furniture, catering, and venue costs.

Before Piper, this process takes hours. A producer opens a blank template. Creates or repurposes section headers manually. Types in crew line items one by one, field by field, rate by rate. When vendor quotes arrive as PDFs, they read each page, transcribe pricing into cells, and manually assign categories. When the budget is done, they scan it themselves under deadline pressure, hoping they catch the errors. When the client asks "what changed?" they compare spreadsheet tabs and write an email from memory.

With Piper, it took minutes.

Smart Start generated a six-section budget scaffold from a natural language description of the event. No blank page, no manual setup.

Smart Add builds crew line items from a single sentence: "One exec producer at 650/day for seven days, one production coordinator at 450/day for five days, and three runners at 150/day for the show day." Five items generated with correct rates, quantities, and section placement.

For a quick reference, the producer wanted to use a quote from a previous show that was in US dollars. The producer uploaded it into Smart Add. The AI extracted every line item, including tables, chairs, soft furnishings, event spaces, and delivery charges, automatically converting USD to GBP and mapping items to the Furniture section. The producer removed two irrelevant charges (additional rental period, credit card service fee) and committed the rest.

Then the moment that defines what Piper can do that didn't exist before: a 13-page catering proposal. Beautifully designed, food photography across pages, pricing scattered throughout. The summary page showed £5,280. But the AI read every page and extracted itemised drink costs, cocktail stations, and beverage packages totalling over £2,000 that the vendor's own summary had omitted. It flagged three staffing positions with roles but no pricing. When we investigated why the initial pass missed some data, we discovered white-on-white text in the PDF. We re-engineered the prompt to search specifically for obscured text, and on subsequent passes the missing data was found. A human reviewing that document would never have seen it. A producer working from the summary page would have missed thousands in costs and unpriced labour.

The producer watching said: "It's actually flagging mistakes ... I've not seen anything like this up to now."

AI Budget Review then analysed the growing budget and flagged a markup discrepancy and questioned a few costs. Ask Piper modelled the impact of adding 100 guests, generating cost projections and a draft client email.

From blank page to reviewed, version-controlled, client-ready budget, with caught errors that would have cost thousands, in a fraction of the time.

Questions / Answers

What measurable results or improvements did it deliver?
(Include any evidence that shows real-world impact.)

Vendor quote processing: 1 hour → under 1 minute.

Budget scaffolding: 20 minutes → seconds. No existing event tool generates a structured budget from a natural language description.

Line item creation: 2 minutes each → under 1 minute per batch.

Budget review: hours → under 60 seconds. One review identified a markup at 2% instead of the project's standard 10% on a £12,000 item, flagging over £900 in margin before client delivery.

Missing cost detection: £2,000+ in omitted costs the AI extracted from a single 13-page vendor quote before the budget was sent to the client. Without that catch, the production company either eats the cost or goes back to the client to explain why the budget has increased. Neither is a good conversation.

Calculation risk: dramatically reduced. Platform-managed arithmetic with locked markup logic. No broken cell references, no accidentally exposed margin data.

Currency conversion: automatic. No manual calculation or specification required.

Client version preparation: 8+ person-hours → one click.

Version comparison: instant. Every change between versions, additions, removals, price adjustments, categorised and generated automatically.

Impact analysis: "What happens if I add 100 people?" answered in seconds with cost projections and a draft client communication.

Development velocity: five months from founding to production-ready platform with four integrated AI capabilities, built by founders who didn't need user research to understand the problem.

An industry expert independently suggested product extensions (Chrome sidebar, email quote processing) that are already on Piper's roadmap. Validation came from a knowledgeable user immediately seeing applications beyond what was shown.

All figures from real production use on real budgets with real vendor documents.

MODEL TRANSPARENCY (optional)

Questions / Answers

What type of AI model or technique does your solution use? Please provide a simple, high-level explanation that helps judges understand the approach (no confidential or proprietary details required).
We built Piper on Anthropic's Claude, and the choice was as much philosophical as technical.

After testing multiple foundation models, Claude stood out for two reasons. First, its structured output capabilities: Piper needs the AI to return precisely formatted financial data, not freeform text. Claude consistently produces output that conforms to strict schemas, including item descriptions, quantities, rates, section placements, and confidence scores, without hallucinating fields or breaking structure. Second, Anthropic's approach to AI safety: for a platform handling real production budgets where a misextracted rate directly costs money, we wanted a model built by a company that thinks carefully about autonomy and constraint.

The AI runs at two speeds. Complex tasks like extracting 40 line items from a multi-page vendor PDF, analysing a complete budget for anomalies, or modelling the financial impact of a scope change go through Claude Sonnet, which handles the deep context these operations require. Lighter tasks like quick help answers and simple workflow questions go through Claude Haiku for speed. The producer gets instant responses for simple queries and thorough analysis for complex ones, without having to choose.

What makes this more than a model integration is the domain layer. Every prompt carries event production knowledge from decades of combined experience. The AI knows that a scenic quote without transport is probably incomplete. It knows that freelancer day rates vary by role and seniority. It knows that a vendor summary page doesn't always match what's in the body of the document. It knows that an outdoor build without weather contingency is a risk that will surface on site. This domain encoding, event-specific operational knowledge rather than generic financial intelligence, is what makes Piper's AI genuinely useful rather than generically capable.

Prompts live in Langfuse, completely separated from the application code. This separation matters because prompt quality determines output quality, and improving one shouldn't require shipping the other. We can refine how the AI interprets a venue hire contract without deploying a new build. Every interaction is traced end-to-end, creating a quality system, not just a log.

No AI output touches budget data without explicit human approval.

The model proposes. The producer disposes.

That principle isn't a restriction on the AI. It's the reason producers trust it enough to change how they work.

All processing occurs via Anthropic's secure API, with row-level database security scoping every query to the authenticated user, JWT authentication, and no client-side secrets.

SUPPORTING MATERIAL

Questions / Answers

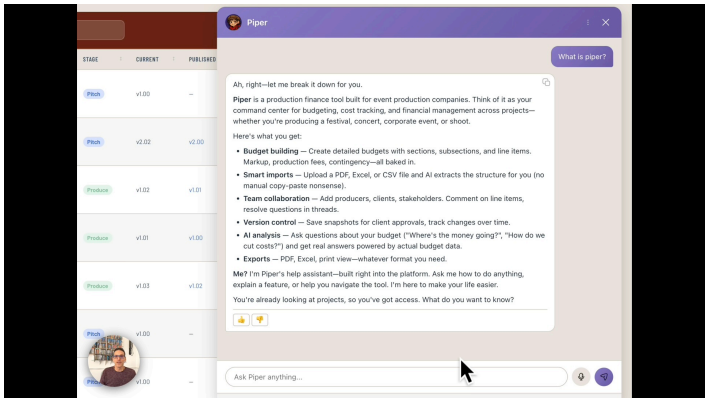
Video Link (optional)

withpiper.ai - modern event budgeting

Ethan Rosch

18:26

1. Additional upload if required, screenshots, dashboards, examples, test results



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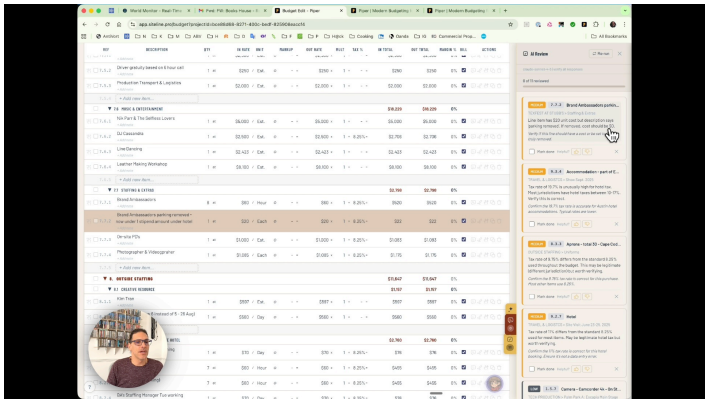
Questions / Answers

2. Additional upload if required, screenshots, dashboards, examples, test results



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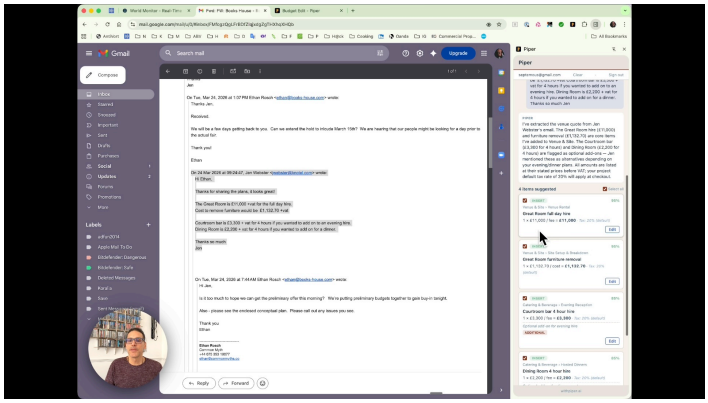

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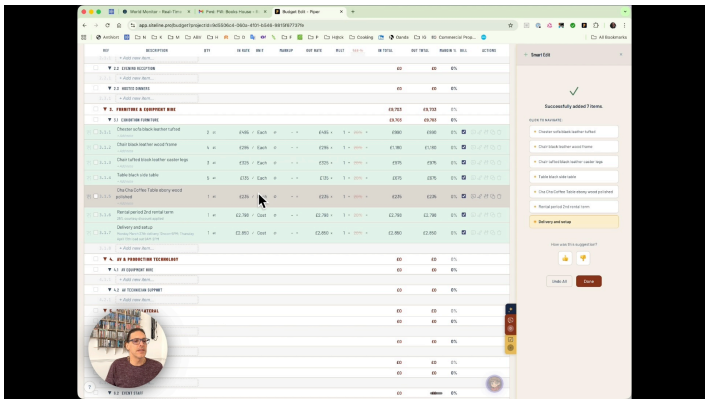

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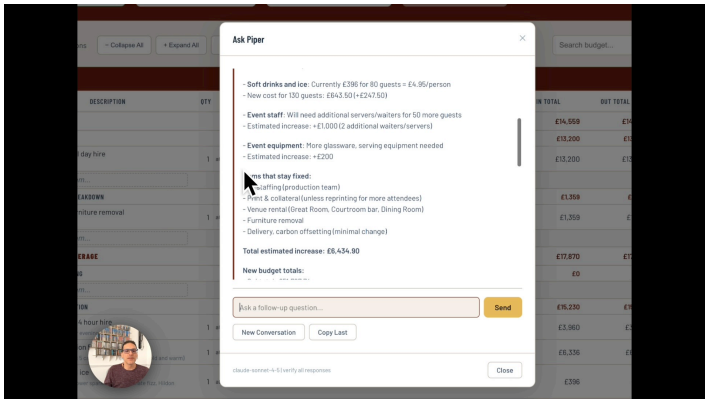
Questions / Answers

5. Additional upload if required, screenshots, dashboards, examples, test results



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DECLARATION FIELD

By completing this nomination you are agreeing to the terms and conditions and declare that this entry form is eligible for entry. You are confirming all facts and figures contained within are accurate and true.

I agree

Scoring

Un-pin scoring panel

Opt-out

Recuse yourself if you have a professional or personal conflict of interest

Scoring is incomplete

Save

Cancel

Criteria	Score
Innovation * How original and forward-thinking is the approach? Whether you built an AI solution, adopted AI within your own events operation, or are bringing an early-stage concept to market, judges want to see genuine originality. Has AI been applied in a new or distinctive way? Does it solve a real problem creatively rather than following the obvious path? Look beyond off-the-shelf deployment and assess the quality of thinking behind the approach.	/ 100

Recuse yourself if you have a professional or personal conflict of interest

Scoring is incomplete ⚠

Criteria	Score
Impact * What difference has this made, or what difference is it credibly expected to make? For live solutions, look for concrete evidence -- engagement rates, time saved, revenue generated, cost reduction, satisfaction scores. For pilot or beta-stage entries, early indicators such as user testing results, pilot outcomes, letters of intent, or projected impact grounded in credible data are all valid. Strong entries will be specific, not vague.	/ 100
Execution * How well has this been implemented or developed? For suppliers and vendors, consider the quality of the build, the robustness of delivery, and how challenges were handled. For organisers, consider how well AI was embedded into operations and how the team managed change. For early-stage entries, assess the quality of the product so far, the clarity of the roadmap, and the credibility of the team's approach. Thoughtful, professional execution at any stage counts highly.	/ 100
Results * What has been achieved, and what does the evidence show? For established solutions, consider client outcomes, retention, testimonials, and industry recognition alongside hard metrics. For organisers, attendee feedback, operational improvements, and stakeholder satisfaction all count. For startups or beta entries, judges should look for credible progress -- pilot conversions, early user feedback, investment secured, or strategic partnerships -- and should assess potential alongside proven outcomes. Do not penalise entries for being early stage; reward evidence of meaningful progress and a clear path to impact.	/ 100
Total	-

Recuse yourself if you have a professional or personal conflict of interest

Scoring is incomplete

Criteria	Score

Feedback

Dictation disable

You speak: English

Text will be: **English**

Start dictation (20s)

Opt-out

Recuse yourself if you have a professional or personal conflict of interest

Scoring is incomplete

Save

Cancel